

1 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

Build a fair riddle

What we are practising

Edit clues for accuracy, specificity and ambiguity.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Compose and test the riddle aloud.

Before you begin

Choose a familiar object such as a map, key or clock.

Keep clues kind and about objects or ideas, not personal traits of real people.

Try it together

1. List three true properties of the chosen object.
2. Turn the properties into clues without using its name.
3. Ask a partner for possible answers and check each against every clue.
4. Revise any clue that accidentally excludes the intended answer or allows too many alternatives.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does your riddle reward reasoning or rely on an unfair hidden assumption?

Space to explore

2 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

The evidence editor

What we are practising

Distinguish evidence, exaggeration and unanswered questions.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Discuss the example aloud and dictate a revision.

Before you begin

Write this fictional report: Eight of ten children at one club chose drawing over chess today.

Use the fictional example; do not collect names or post claims about real children.

Try it together

1. Read the headline: All children dislike chess!
2. Underline words the report does not support.
3. Write a more accurate headline that includes the group or sample.
4. List two things you would need to know before making a broader claim.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does choosing drawing mean a child dislikes chess?

Space to explore

3 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

A poem with a hidden word

What we are practising

Write within a letter constraint while using sensory detail.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Dictate each line to a partner.

Before you begin

Write SUN vertically down the page, one letter per line.

There is no requirement to share personal feelings or experiences.

Try it together

1. Begin three lines with S, U and N, in that order.
2. Use at least one detail you could see, hear or feel.
3. Read the poem aloud and replace one vague word with a clearer image.
4. Ask a partner to find the hidden word and describe the mood.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does each line contribute to the poem as well as fitting its letter?

Space to explore

4 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

Keep the meaning, cut the words

What we are practising

Prioritize information and check that a summary remains accurate.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Compare two spoken versions instead of counting written words.

Before you begin

Write: The library will hold a free drawing session on Saturday at ten in the morning. Bring a pencil. Paper will be provided. The session lasts one hour.

All event details are fictional; do not treat the notice as an actual invitation.

Try it together

1. Mark the event, place, day, start time, duration, cost and item to bring.
2. Write a shorter notice preserving those details.
3. Ask a partner to answer the seven marked questions using only your version.
4. Restore any essential detail that disappeared.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Which words can disappear without changing what a reader needs to do?

Space to explore

5 / 5 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

Make a reasoned proposal

What we are practising

Connect a claim to reasons and respond respectfully to another view.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Present the proposal aloud with three brief notes.

Before you begin

Imagine a garden with room for one new feature: a reading bench or a play table.

Keep disagreements about the proposal and avoid personal criticism.

Try it together

1. Choose a feature and give two reasons linked to how people would use it.
2. State one reasonable concern about your choice.
3. Suggest a practical way to address that concern.
4. Ask a partner to argue for the other choice, then revise one part of your proposal.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What information would help the group decide between the options?

Space to explore

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

1. Build a fair riddle

A little hint

For a map, you might mention labelled places and drawn routes rather than claiming all maps show rivers.

Answer / what to notice

Many riddles work; accept another answer if it fits every clue, then refine the wording.

Testing with a listener reveals meanings the writer may have overlooked.

Make it easier

Start with a picture and two direct clues.

Take it further

Write a version in each language, adapting wordplay so both remain solvable.

Another day, away from the screen

Make a three-riddle family booklet with explained answers on the back.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

2. The evidence editor

A little hint

The report measures one choice on one day in one club.

Answer / what to notice

A supported headline is: Eight of ten children at this club chose drawing today.

Preference in one setting does not prove dislike, and a small local group does not represent all children.

Make it easier

Choose between an accurate and an exaggerated headline.

Take it further

Write a balanced caption showing both the count and the limits of the report.

Another day, away from the screen

Invent a harmless survey result and exchange headline-editing challenges.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

3. A poem with a hidden word

A little hint

A first line might be Soft light warms the windowsill.

Answer / what to notice

Any three coherent lines with initial letters S, U, N meet the letter rule; rhyme is optional.

The initial letters create the hidden word, while specific images give the poem meaning.

Make it easier

Use one descriptive word per letter.

Take it further

Choose a five-letter word and sustain one theme across all five lines.

Another day, away from the screen

Make an illustrated page and read it to a willing listener.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

4. Keep the meaning, cut the words

A little hint

A compact phrase such as Saturday, 10-11 am preserves the start and duration.

Answer / what to notice

One version: Free library drawing session, Saturday 10-11 am. Bring a pencil; paper provided.

A good summary removes repetition while retaining facts needed to understand or act on the message.

Make it easier

Shorten only the first two sentences.

Take it further

Write a full notice and a very short reminder, explaining which context each needs.

Another day, away from the screen

Condense instructions from a familiar game while keeping every necessary rule.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

5. Make a reasoned proposal

A little hint

A useful reason describes a need, such as a place to rest, rather than only saying it is best.

Answer / what to notice

Either choice can be defended; a strong proposal has relevant reasons, acknowledges a concern and suggests a response.

Considering an objection can improve a proposal rather than simply weaken it.

Make it easier

Give one reason for each option before choosing.

Take it further

Set a fictional budget and compare how each option meets several needs.

Another day, away from the screen

Write a one-paragraph proposal for improving a pretend reading corner.